

Russian, Step by Step, Root by Root

A gentle, etymology-driven introduction to Russian

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Starter edition — five cumulative chapters of short lessons.

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Preface

This book teaches Russian one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It assumes no Russian and no Cyrillic. Every section takes one small expression, introduces only the letters, sounds, or grammar that expression needs, connects it to history you may already know, and ends by asking for it back.

Russian is a Slavic language, a cousin of English far enough back that the family resemblance survives in surprising places — *three* is *tri*, *sister* is *sestrá* — and it is worth knowing which resemblances are real and which are traps. This book flags both.

Stress matters enormously in Russian, and ordinary Cyrillic does not print it. So the romanization here marks the stressed vowel with an acute accent, and then gradually yields to the script as you come to read it.

This is a starter edition: five chapters, complete in themselves, with more being written. Chapters 1 and 2 were written straight into L^AT_EX; chapters 3 to 5 are generated from the same lesson files the audio course reads, so the printed page and the spoken lesson cannot drift apart.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Russian out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real

words from the first page rather than drilling a chart.

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Chapter 1

Greetings and courtesy

This chapter grows a complete courtesy exchange from six expressions. Cyrillic arrives inside each word, starting with the four letters that most often fool a Latin-alphabet reader.

1.1 привет (*privét*) — informal hello

Read only what this expression needs

Read left to right. In **привет**, **п** says *p*, **р** says *r*, **и** says “ee,” **в** says *v*, **е** begins with a light “ye,” and **т** says *t*. Two shapes lie to a Latin-trained eye: **р** looks like *p* but says *r*; **в** looks like *B* but says *v*. Stress the final syllable: *pri-VYET*.

Where the expression came from

Privét contains the old *vet-* family associated with speaking, news, and counsel. The same family is visible in **совет** *sovét*, a council or piece of advice — the word behind the international name *Soviet*. A greeting and a council both begin with words exchanged.

Use it now

Use **привет** with a friend, child, or someone you already address informally. It is not the safest first word for a stranger in a formal setting.

One-minute checkpoint

Which two letters are false friends? Point to **р** and say *r*; point to **в** and say *v*. Then read **привет** once with final stress.

1.2 здравствуйте (*zdrávstvuyte*) — formal hello

Read only what this expression needs

This long word is learned as a sound shape before every letter is writable. Aim first for *ZDRAST-vuy-tye*: everyday speech compresses the central cluster and the first written **В** is often not heard. Stress stays near the front. Recognizing a contraction is enough; perfect consonant gymnastics are not.

Where the expression came from

здравствуйте is historically an instruction: “be healthy.” Its core is **здрав-**, the health family also visible in **здоровье** “health.” The ending **-те** is plural and also polite, so the word carries respect in its grammar as well as goodwill in its root.

Use it now

Use **здравствуйте** with a stranger, an older person, a professional contact, or a group. Contrast only the register: **привет** informal; **здравствуйте** polite or plural.

One-minute checkpoint

What wish hides inside the formal greeting? “Be healthy.” Which ending helps make it polite? **-те**. Choose the formal greeting for a new teacher.

1.3 спасибо (*spasíbo*) — thank you

Read only what this expression needs

Reuse **с** *s*, another false friend because it looks like Latin *C*. The stress is in the middle: *spa-SEE-ba*. The final written **о** is unstressed and reduces toward an *a*-like sound. Russian spelling preserves the word while speech weakens the vowel.

Where the expression came from

спасибо wore down from **спаси Бог**: “God save [you].” English *good-bye* grew from “God be with ye,” and Spanish *adiós* points “to God.”

Different languages turned short blessings into ordinary social words; modern *spasibo* is simply “thank you.”

Use it now

Build a safe formal exchange: Здравствуйте! — Здравствуйте! — Спасибо. One greeting and one thanks are enough.

One-minute checkpoint

Where is the stress in спасибо? On *-si-*. What happens to final unstressed о? It sounds more *a*-like. Say *spa-SEE-ba*.

1.4 да (*da*) — yes

Read only what this expression needs

Two letters: д *d* and а *a* as in “father.” Neither is a false friend. Read да as one clear syllable.

Use it now

Да is a complete “yes.” Russian also uses it to keep a conversation moving, rather like “right” or “well,” but affirmative *da* is the only job due now.

One-minute checkpoint

Read да. Answer a harmless yes/no question with it once.

1.5 нет (*nyet*) — no, literally not-is

Read only what this expression needs

Н is the third major false friend: it looks like Latin *H* but says *n*. At the start of this word е carries a “ye” sound, then т gives *t*: *nyet*.

Where the expression came from

нет compresses an older combination of **не** “not” and a form of **есть** “is/exists”: roughly “there is not.” The negative *ne* goes back to Indo-European *ne, a deep relative of English *no*, *not*, *never*, and *nay*.

Use it now

Contrast complete answers only: **да** — yes; **нет** — no.

One-minute checkpoint

What sound does **н** make? Say *n*, then answer “no” with **нет**.

1.6 пожалуйста (*pozhalusta*) — please and you are welcome

Read only what this expression needs

Meet **ж**, the sound *zh* in English “measure.” The careful spelling is longer than ordinary speech: aim for *pa-ZHAL-sta*. Stress *-zh* and allow the middle syllable to contract after you can recognize the full word.

Where the expression came from

The word grew from **пожалуй**, a form connected with granting or doing a favour, plus the old particle **-ста**. That favour-history explains both modern jobs: a request can begin “please,” and a received thanks can be answered “you are welcome.”

Use it now

Ask with **пожалуйста**; answer **спасибо** with **пожалуйста**. Context chooses between “please” and “you are welcome.”

One-minute checkpoint

What new sound does **ж** carry? *Zh*. Answer **Спасибо** with **Пожалуйста**.

1.7 Chapter 1 retrieval — choose the register

Use it now

For a friend: Привет! For a stranger: Здравствуйте! Continue either exchange with Спасибо. — Пожалуйста. Then practise the answer pair Да. — Нет.

One-minute checkpoint

Without looking back, produce: informal hello, formal hello, thank you, you are welcome, yes, no. Now read the six Cyrillic forms in the same order.

Chapter 2

Introducing yourself

The first chapter supplied courtesy moves. This chapter adds pronouns, one naming construction, its matching question, and a complete first conversation. Case appears only through the forms the exchange needs.

2.1 я (*ya*) — I

Read only what this expression needs

я looks like a mirrored Latin *R*, but it is a vowel letter pronounced “ya.” Learn the whole word and letter together: я means “I.” Do not copy the Latin sound onto the Cyrillic shape.

Where the expression came from

First-person pronouns resist borrowing. Russian я continues Proto-Slavic *azŭ, from the ancient Indo-European pronoun family also behind Latin *ego*, German *ich*, and English *I*. The modern shapes differ dramatically because this tiny word has travelled inside each language for millennia.

One-minute checkpoint

What does я say and mean? “Ya, I.” Read it without calling it an *R*.

2.2 ТЫ, ВЫ (*ty, vy*) — two forms of you

Read only what this expression needs

Both words contain **Ы**, a vowel English lacks. Begin with the “ee” of *ill*, then draw the tongue slightly back. **ТЫ** is informal singular; **ВЫ** is plural or polite. The first letters are familiar **Т** *t* and the false friend **В** *v*.

Where the expression came from

English once kept a number and familiarity contrast in *thou* and *you*. Russian still distinguishes **ТЫ** and **ВЫ**. Polite plurals also appear in French *vous*; German formal *Sie* instead uses a third-person form, while Spanish *usted* grew from a title meaning “your grace.” Similar social work can arise through different grammar.

Use it now

Use **ТЫ** with one friend or child. Use **ВЫ** with a stranger, in a formal relationship, or with more than one person. When unsure with an adult stranger, begin with **ВЫ**.

One-minute checkpoint

Choose for one close friend: **ТЫ**. Choose for a new professor: **ВЫ**. Produce the unfamiliar vowel once without turning it into plain “ee.”

2.3 МЕНЯ ЗОВУТ ... (*menyá zovút ...*) — my name is ...

Read only what this expression needs

меня ends in the new **Я** sound; **зовут** reuses **В** *v* and **Т** *t*. Stress the final syllable of each part: *me-NYA zo-VOOT*. Insert the name after the verb: **Меня зовут Анна**.

Use it now

The literal pattern is “[they] call me Anna.” Russian supplies no separate word for “my” or “name” here. The plural verb **зовут** has an unnamed general subject — people call me — much like English “they say it will

rain.” Learn the frame, not a word-for-word English substitution.

Where the expression came from

Меня is the object form paired with subject **я**. English preserves a small version of this contrast in *I/me*; Russian case changes every noun and pronoun. No table is due: notice only that “I” and “me” have different shapes in both languages.

One-minute checkpoint

Does the Russian sentence contain a word for “name”? No. Replace Anna with your name and say **Меня зовут ...** once.

2.4 как вас зовут? (*kak vas zovút?*) — what is your name?

Read only what this expression needs

как is “how.” **вас** is the object form associated here with polite **вы**; **зовут** is unchanged from your answer. Russian asks literally: “How do they call you?”

Where the expression came from

Russian *kak*, French *comment*, and Spanish *cómo* all frame the naming question as “how.” English asks “what” because it treats the answer as a possessed name. The same social question can be organized around an action or a thing.

Use it now

Pair the question and answer: **Как вас зовут? — Меня зовут Анна.** Keep **зовут** exactly the same.

One-minute checkpoint

Which word asks “how”? **как**. Ask the polite question, then answer it with your name.

2.5 очень приятно (*óchen priyátno*) — pleased to meet you

Read only what this expression needs

очень is “very”; its final **ь** is a soft sign, which has no sound of its own but changes the consonant before it. **приятно** is “pleasant.” Read the phrase literally as “very pleasant.”

Where the expression came from

приятно belongs to a Slavic family of favour and affection, traced to Indo-European *preyH- “love, please.” Germanic used the same deep family for English *friend*, a person who is dear; the usual historical account also connects *free*. Russian and English preserve opposite branches of the same old idea.

Use it now

Russian needs no spoken “it is” in this present-tense expression: **Очень приятно.** literally “Very pleasant.” Use it after names are exchanged.

One-minute checkpoint

What does the soft sign pronounce by itself? Nothing. Say the literal two words, “very pleasant,” then the Russian phrase.

2.6 A complete formal introduction

Use it now

Read one turn at a time:

1. A: Здравствуйте!
2. B: Здравствуйте!
3. A: Как вас зовут?
4. B: Меня зовут Анна.
5. A: Очень приятно.

6. В: Спасибо.

Every expression is already known. Only their conversation order is new.

One-minute checkpoint

Cover the list. Rebuild the exchange from these cues: formal hello, ask a name, give a name, pleased to meet you, thank you.

2.7 The informal switch

Read only what this expression needs

Case gives the three pronouns different object forms: я “I” becomes **меня** “me”; ты becomes **тебя**; вы becomes **вас**. Learn these as three pairs, not as a complete case table.

Use it now

With one friend, replace **Здравствуйте** with **Привет** and ask **Как тебя зовут?** The answer stays **Меня зовут ...**; the verb **зовут** does not change.

One-minute checkpoint

Which two pieces change from the formal exchange? The greeting and the object pronoun: **Здравствуйте / вас** become **Привет / тебя**. Produce the informal question once.

Chapter 3

Six Verbs, and the One You Never Say

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I do in Russian with six everyday verbs — **быть, жить, знать, говорить, видеть, идти** — put each of them in the **я** form, negate one with **не**, and say a sentence like «**Я — Анна**» the way Russian does, by leaving the verb out entirely.

Say **иду** — «*I am going*», one trip, right now — and hear why Russian splits going-there-once from going-there-often, a distinction English carries in tone and Russian carries in the verb itself. Then place **идти** against the two verb families the chapter has been sorting, and meet the **го-** that English also inherited in *go / went*.

3.1 **быть** — “to be”

Chapter 2 ended on a Russian sentence with no verb in it at all. This lesson is the verb that wasn’t there.

You’ll want to know first — **быть**

быть — *byt’* — to be

Four letters, and you have met all four already: **б** from **спасибо**, **ы** from **ты**, **т** from **привет**, and the soft sign **ь** from **очень**. Nothing new to decode — which is rare, and worth enjoying.

The **ь** is not a sound; it softens the **т** in front of it. That ending **-ть** is how almost every Russian verb names itself, the way English puts *to* in front.

Grammar Lens: the tense Russian will not say

English: *I am a student.* Russian:

Я студент. — *ya studént* — literally “**I student.**”

There is no word between them. Not a short one, not a quiet one — **none**. Russian does not use **быть** in the present tense; you link two things by setting them side by side.

The verb was not lost. Push the sentence into the past and it walks back in: **Я был студентом** — *ya byl studéntom* — “I was a student.”

The present is the one place it goes silent.

Chapter 1 already showed you the survivor: **нет** is **не** + **есть**, “not-is.” **Есть** means **there is**, never *am*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

быть comes from Proto-Slavic **byti*, from PIE **b^huH-*, “to grow, to become.” Say *byt’* and then say **be** — that is the same root, barely worn.

Its cousins: English **be** and **been**, German *bin*, Latin *fuī* “I was” (which gave English **future**), Sanskrit *bhávati*.

Now the part worth keeping. English *be* is stitched from **three** different ancient roots — *be* from **b^huH-*, *is* and *am* from **h₁es-*, *was* and *were* from **wes-*. Russian holds two of those apart and lets you watch: **быть** is the **b^huH-* one, **есть** is the **h₁es-* one — the same root as English **is**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**быть**” — *byt’*, with a soft final t
- “**Я студент**” — and feel the gap where English puts *am*
- the two roots Russian keeps apart — “**быть ... есть**”
- the English pair — “**be ... is**”

Before you move on

Say “to be.” (БЫТЬ.) Now say “I am a student.” (Я студент — two words, and no verb.) Is the verb gone from the language? (No — был returns in the past; only the present drops it.) Which English word is БЫТЬ? (Be — same root, **b^huH-*.) And which English word is ЕСТЬ? (Is.) Next: ЖИТЬ, “to live.”

3.2 ЖИТЬ — “to live”

Last lesson gave you a verb Russian refuses to say. This one you say constantly — and it is the first time you will put an ending on one.

You’ll want to know first — ЖИТЬ

ЖИТЬ — *zhít’* — to live

Same -ть ending as БЫТЬ, and no new letters. The first one, Ж, you met buried in пожалуйста: it is the *zh* of English *measure* or *pleasure* — a *sh* with the voice switched on. English never gives that sound a letter of its own; Russian gives it one.

So: *zhít’*, one syllable, soft *t* at the end.

Grammar Lens: the ending that means “I”

Я живу. — *ya zhivú* — I live.

Two things happened. A -у arrived on the end, and that -у is the whole signal for I — it is what *am*, *do* and *-s* are in English, packed into one letter. And a в surfaced in the middle that the infinitive never showed you: жи-ть becomes жив-у.

That is normal. A Russian verb’s dictionary form and its working stem are allowed to differ, so you learn the pair, not the one.

Switch to *you*, and the ending switches: ты живёшь — *ty zhivyósh* — “you live.” The person lives in the ending; Russian can therefore drop the pronoun entirely and still be perfectly clear.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ЖИТЬ goes back to PIE **g^weih₃-*, “to live,” and the family is enormous: Latin *vīvere* gave English **vivid**, **survive**, **revive**, **vital**; Greek *bíos* gave **biology**, and Greek *zōē* gave **zoo** and **zodiac**.

But the cousin worth carrying is the plain English one: **quick**. It meant **alive**, not fast — the speed came later, from how the living move. It is still frozen in the phrase *the quick and the dead*, in *cut to the quick* (cut to the living flesh), and in **quicksilver**, the metal that behaves as if alive.

So ЖИТЬ is **quick** in its older sense: to be among the living.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ЖИТЬ” — *zhit’*, with the *measure* sound in front
- “Я живу” — and land on the **-y**
- the pair — “живу ... живёшь”
- the old English meaning — “**quick** ... alive”

Before you move on

Say “to live.” (ЖИТЬ.) Say “I live.” (Я живу — and the **-y** is doing the work.) What did English *quick* once mean? (**Alive** — as in *the quick and the dead*.) Name two Latin cousins. (*Vivid*, *survive* — from *vīvere*.) Next: ЗНАТЬ, “to know.”

3.3 ЗНАТЬ — “to know”

The most useful sentence a beginner owns is not *hello*. It is *I don’t know* — and after this lesson you will have it.

You’ll want to know first — ЗНАТЬ

ЗНАТЬ — *znat’* — to know

No new letters, and the same **-ТЬ** that ended **БЫТЬ** and **ЖИТЬ**. Say the **З** and **Н** together with no vowel between them — *zn-*, exactly as English does in the middle of *magnet* but never at the start of a word.

In the present it takes the ending you already own:

Я знаю. — *ya znáyu* — **I know.**

That **-ю** is not a new ending. It is the same **-у** you put on **живу**, spelled so it carries a *y*-glide in front — the same glide **е** carries in **привет**. Russian writes the glide into the vowel instead of adding a letter for it.

Grammar Lens: не, the whole of “don’t”

Я не знаю. — *ya ne znáyu* — **I don’t know.**

You met **не** in Chapter 1, hidden inside **нет** — **не** + **есть**, “not-is.” Here it stands on its own, and it is the entire machinery of English *don’t*, *doesn’t* and *didn’t*: one small word, parked directly in front of the verb, never changing shape.

English needs a helper verb to negate — *I know* becomes *I do not know*, with a *do* that appears from nowhere. Russian adds nothing and borrows nothing. Put **не** in front, and you are done.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ЗНАТЬ is PIE **ǵneh₃-*, “to know,” and so is English **know** — the silent *k* in *know* is the fossil of a sound Russian still pronounces in **ЗН-**.

Down the Latin branch: *nōscere* gave **notice**, **notion**, **note**, **ignore** (*not-knowing*), **recognize**, **incognito**, and — through *nōbilis*, “knowable, well-known” — **noble**. Down the Greek branch: *gignōskein* gave **diagnosis**, **prognosis**, **agnostic**. English **ken** and **cunning** come straight down the Germanic branch beside *know*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**ЗНАТЬ**” — *znat'*, both consonants together
- “**Я знаю**” — the **-ю** is your **-у** wearing a glide
- “**Я не знаю**” — and notice you added nothing else
- the family — “**know** ... *notice* ... *ignore* ... *diagnosis*”

Before you move on

Say “to know.” (**Знать.**) Say “I don’t know.” (**Я не знаю.**) What does Russian add to negate a verb, besides **не**? (**Nothing** — no helper verb at all.) Which English word is **знать**? (**Know** — and its silent *k* is the sound Russian kept.) Next: **говорить**, “to speak.”

3.4 говорить — “to speak”

Your first new letter in three lessons, and an English word that looks like a relative and is not one.

You’ll want to know first — говорить

говорить — *govorít’* — to speak, to talk

One letter here is **new**: **г**. It is Greek **gamma** (**Г**) with the corner rounded off, and it says a hard **g**, as in *go* — never the *j* of *gem*.

Everything else you have met. And the two **os** behave the way **спасибо** taught you: an **o** away from the stress slides towards *a*. The stress falls on the last syllable, so this is **ga-va-RIT’**. Russian spells the *o*; your mouth says *a*.

Grammar Lens: verbs come in two families

Я говорю. — *ya gavarýú* — I speak.

The **I** ending is the same **-ю** you put on **знаю**. Every Russian verb in the present ends the same way for *I*. Then switch to *you*, and the two families separate:

- ты знаешь — *ty znáyesh* — you know
- ты говоришь — *ty gavarísh* — you speak

An **-e-** against an **-и-**. That one vowel is the whole difference, and it is why you learn the *you* form alongside the dictionary form: it names the family, and the remaining endings follow from it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

говорить is built on the old Slavic noun *govorъ, “a murmur, a din, the noise of many voices.” Russian still keeps говор for the buzz of a crowd or a regional way of talking. Most etymologists read the root as **imitative** — the word sounds like what it names — which is honest but means there is no tidy English cousin to hand you. Where a root is uncertain, this book says so.

What there *is* to hand you is a trap. **Govern** is **not** related. That is Latin *gubernāre*, “to steer a ship,” from Greek *kybernân* — the same word that gave English **cybernetics** and every **cyber-** since. A governor steers; a говор is a noise. Two roots that never met.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the new letter — “г is gamma, and says *g* as in *go*”
- “говорить” — *ga-va-RIT'*, both *os* leaning towards *a*
- “Я говорю” — same -ю as знаю
- the two families — “знаешь ... говоришь”

Before you move on

What sound is г? (A hard **g**, from Greek gamma.) Say “I speak.” (Я говорю.) Which vowel separates the two verb families in the *you* form? (-e- in знаешь against -и- in говоришь.) Is говорить related to English *govern*? (**No** — *govern* is Greek *kybernân*, “to steer.”) Next: видеть, “to see.”

3.5 видеть — “to see”

One root, two meanings, and half of them ended up in English as words about **knowing** rather than about eyes.

You’ll want to know first — видеть

видеть — *vídet'* — to see

No new letters. Two you should keep honest, though: **В** says *v*, not *b*, and **И** says *ee* — the pair that fooled you in **привет**.

Stress lands on the **first** syllable here — *VEE-dyet'* — the opposite of **говорить**. Russian never prints its stress, so it travels with the word.

The *you* form tells you the family, exactly as promised last lesson:

ТЫ ВИДИШЬ — *ty vídish* — **you see**

An **-ишь**, so **видеть** belongs with **говорить**, not with **знать**.

Grammar Lens: the letter that swaps for “I”

Now the surprise:

Я ВИЖУ. — *ya vízhu* — **I see.**

The **Д** has become **Ж** — the *measure* sound from **жить**. The ending is the ordinary **-у**; it is the consonant in front of it that shifted.

This happens in the **I** form and nowhere else in the present. **ТЫ ВИДИШЬ**, and everyone else, keep their **Д**. So the pattern to carry is small and exact: **ВИЖУ**, then **ВИДИШЬ** — and after that the verb behaves.

English does the same trick and has stopped noticing: *spea*k against *speech*, *break* against *breach*, *bake* against *batch*. A consonant softening beside a front vowel, in both languages, for the same ancient reason.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

видеть is PIE **weid-*, and that root carried **two** senses at once: *to see*, and — because what you have seen is what you know — *to know*.

The seeing branch, through Latin *vidēre*: **video**, **vision**, **visit**, **evident**, **provide**, **review**, **advise**. Through Greek *eîdos*: **idea** and **idol**.

The knowing branch came into English directly: **wit**, **wise**, **wisdom**, **witness** — someone who knows because they saw. Sanskrit took the same turn: the **Veda** is “what has been seen,” meaning knowledge.

Russian kept both halves as two verbs: **видеть** for the eyes, and the older **ведать** for knowing — the *ved-* of *Veda*, still alive in Russian.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “видеть” — *VEE-dyet’*, stress at the front
- the odd pair — “вижу ... видишь”
- which family it joins — “видишь, like говоришь”
- the two branches — “*video* ... *wit*”

Before you move on

Say “to see.” (Видеть.) Say “I see.” (Я вижу — the *д* swapped to *ж*.) Does that swap happen anywhere else in the present? (**No** — the *I* form only.) What second meaning did **weid-* carry? (**To know** — hence *wit*, *wise*, *Veda*.) Next: *идти*, “to go.”

3.6 идти — “to go”

English has one verb for going. Russian has two, and picks between them on a distinction English hides inside its tenses.

You’ll want to know first — *идти*

идти — *idtí* — **to go** (on foot, and under way right now)

No new letters, and only four of them. The *дт* in the middle is not really pronounced as two sounds — Russians say *it-TEE*, with the stress at the end.

The endings are ones you already have:

Я иду. — *ya idú* — **I’m going.**

>

Ты идёшь. — *ty idyósh* — **you’re going.**

An *-y* for *I*, and an *-ешь* ending for *you*, so *идти* sits with *знать*, not with *говорить*.

Grammar Lens: going now against going often

Russian keeps a **second** verb for the same activity:

Я иду — I am on my way, **now**, in one direction.

>

Я хожу — *ya khazhú* — I go, **as a habit**, back and forth.

That is not a tense difference. They are two separate verbs, and Russian makes you choose one before you can open your mouth.

English draws the same line with grammar instead: *I'm going* against *I go*. You know the distinction perfectly — you have just never had to choose a **verb** for it. Every Russian verb of motion comes in such a pair, so this one teaches the pattern.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

идти is PIE **h₁ei-*, “to go” — the same root as Latin *īre*, which gave English **exit** (“he goes out”), **transit**, **initial**, **itinerary**, **ambition** (*ambīre*, “to go around” canvassing votes) and **perish** (*perīre*, “to go through, to be lost”).

Now the good part. The past of идти is шёл — *shol* — which shares **no root** with it at all. A verb this common wears out and patches the hole with a second verb; that is called **suppletion**.

English does exactly this. *Go* has no past of its own either: **went** was taken from *wend* and kept. So идти → шёл is *go* → *went*, in two languages, for one reason — the words we use most wear out fastest.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “идти” — *it-TEE*
- “Я иду” — on my way this minute
- the contrast — “иду ... хожу”
- the two broken verbs — “идти ... шёл”, “go ... went”

Before you move on

Say “I’m on my way.” (Я иду.) And “I go there regularly”? (Я хожу — a different verb, not a different tense.) What is the past of идти? (Шёл — another root altogether, like English *went*.) Name two English cousins of **h₁ei-*. (*Exit*, *transit* — or *itinerary*.) That

is six Russian verbs, and one of them you will spend your life not saying.

Chapter 4

Verbs of the Mind and the Page

***By the end of this chapter:** I can say what I think, understand, read and write in Russian, name the finished partner each of those verbs travels with, and read the letter ш that has been hiding in words I already say.*

Say all four verbs of the chapter in the I form — я думаю, я понимаю, я читаю, я пишу — then name each one's finished partner, put the stress on the end of писать where it belongs, and read the ш you have been decoding since живёшь.

4.1 думать — “to think”

Six verbs behind you. This one opens the largest fact about Russian verbs.

You'll want to know first — думать

думать — *dúmat'* — to think

No new letters, and the -ть of знать. Stress on the first syllable, and it never moves: **DOO-mat'**.

Я думаю. — *ya dúmayu* — I think.

That -ю is the one you put on знаю. And ты думаешь — an -ешь, so думать files with знать, not говорить.

Three verbs of the head now: я знаю is a fact I hold, я вижу is what reaches my eyes, я думаю is what goes on behind them.

Grammar Lens: every Russian verb travels with a partner

Russian verbs come in **pairs**. One member is the **doing** — under way, repeated, unfinished. The other is the **deed done**, seen whole.

Думать is the first kind; its partner **подумать** is not “to think” but “to have a thought, and be done with it.”

You have met the instinct once. **Идти** was going *now, one way*, with a separate partner for going *as a habit* — one small family of motion verbs. This is a **different** distinction, applied to nearly **every verb in the language**.

So one job per verb: learn its partner’s **name**. What a pair does to a sentence is a later lesson.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

дума is the Russian noun for **a thought** — and for a body that thinks: the State **Дума** is the lower house of the Russian parliament, this same word.

Its own origin carries a hedge. The standard account makes **дума** an early borrowing from **Gothic** *dōms*, “a judgement” — behind English **doom** (a judgement before it was a fate) and **deem**. If so, **думать** and *doom* are relatives **by contact**, not by descent; a minority prefer an inherited root.

Latin’s *cogito, ergo sum* is built on the same idea, and its other pieces are yours: the **-o** of *cogito* is Latin **ego**, the pronoun Russian keeps as **я**; and *fuī*, “I was,” is **быть**’s root, English **be**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**думать**” — *DOO-mat’*, stress on the front
- the three heads — “**я знаю ... я вижу ... я думаю**”
- the pair — “**думать ... подумать**”, the doing and the done

Before you move on

Say “I think.” (**Я думаю.**) Which family does **думать** join, **знаешь** or **говоришь**? (**Знаешь.**) What is **подумать** beside **думать**, and how many verbs have such a partner? (The **finished** member; nearly

all.) Which English word does the standard account attach **дума** to?
(**Doom**, by borrowing.)

4.2 ПОНИМАТЬ — “to understand”

The most useful sentence a traveller owns is short, and after this lesson it is yours: *I don’t understand*.

You’ll want to know first — ПОНИМАТЬ

ПОНИМАТЬ — *ponimát’* — **to understand**

No new letters. Stress on the last syllable, and both **os** lean towards *a* away from it: **па-ни-МАТ’**.

Я **понимаю**. — *ya panimáyu* — **I understand**.

The same **-ю** as **думаю**. And now the sentence worth more than the rest:

Я **не понимаю**. — *ya ne panimáyu* — **I don’t understand**.

He does the whole job, exactly as in **я не знаю**: one word in front of the verb, no helper borrowed from anywhere. Say those syllables to a Russian speaker and the conversation slows down for you.

Grammar Lens: the partner, and a warning about its shape

Думать took **подумать**: a prefix on the front, nothing else disturbed. Do not expect that every time.

Понимать’s partner is **понять** — same root, but the middle of the word has been squeezed out, **-ним-** against **-ня-**. Russian builds a pair by prefix, by a reshaped stem, or by both, and the shape is learned with the verb.

The job is unchanged: **ПОНИМАТЬ**, **ПОНЯТЬ**, said together, one entry.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ПОНИМАТЬ is **по-** plus a root meaning simply **to take**: Indo-European **h₁em-*, which came down the Latin branch as *emere*, “to take, and so to buy.” English took the family whole — **exempt** (taken out), **redeem**

(bought back), **example** (taken as a specimen), **premium**, **prompt**, **assume**, **consume**.

So **понимать** literally says **take hold of**. English says the same and has stopped noticing: **comprehend** is Latin *com-prehendere*, “to seize together”; **grasp** is what a hand does; German **begreifen** is *greifen*, “to grip.”

Set that beside the two pictures Russian already gave you. **Знать** was **ǵnehz-*, English **know** — knowledge you simply *have*. **Видеть** was **weid-*, which meant *see* and *know* at once and gave English **wit** and **wise** — knowledge you *saw*. Now understanding as something you *caught*. And unlike **думать**, which arrived by Gothic borrowing, this one is inherited straight down.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**понимать**” — *pa-ni-MAT*’, both *os* leaning to *a*
- “**Я понимаю**” then “**Я не понимаю**” — one word added, nothing else
- the pair — “**понимать ... понять**”, the squeezed middle
- the picture — “take hold” ... *comprehend*, *grasp*

Before you move on

Say “I don’t understand.” (**Я не понимаю**.) Name **понимать**’s partner and say how its shape differs from **подумать**’s. (**Понять** — the stem is reshaped, not just prefixed.) What does the root of **понимать** mean? (**To take** — as *comprehend* and *grasp* also do.) And which of your knowing-verbs is a borrowing rather than an inheritance? (**Думать**, from Gothic.)

4.3 ЧИТАТЬ — “to read”

English says *I read* and *I am reading* and means two things. Russian cannot — and the reason is a verb it refuses to say.

You'll want to know first — ЧИТАТЬ

ЧИТАТЬ — *chítát'* — to read

No new letters: Ч you have been reading since **очень**, and it says the *ch* of *cheese*. Stress on the last syllable, **chi-ТАТ'**.

Я читаю. — *ya chítáyu* — I read.

The same -ю, and ты читаешь puts it with **знать** and **думать**. Two verbs, one ordinary sentence:

Я читаю и понимаю. — *ya chítáyu i panimáyu* — I read and I understand.

Grammar Lens: one present tense, two English sentences

Я читаю is *I read* and *I am reading*. Russian has one present tense and it covers both.

There is a reason, and you hold it. English builds *I am reading* out of **be** plus *-ing*; Russian's **быть** has no present tense to build with — the missing verb of Chapter 3, the one Я студент does without. With no auxiliary, Russian never grew the machinery.

The work English does with *am reading* against *read* is carried instead by the pair. ЧИТАТЬ is the ongoing member; ПРОЧИТАТЬ is the finished one — to read a thing **through**, to the end.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ЧИТАТЬ rests on an old Slavic root meaning **to count, to reckon, to heed**, and Russian keeps the family in plain sight: ЧИСЛО is a *number*, ЧЕСТЬ is *honour*, ПОЧИТАТЬ is *to hold in esteem*. Counting, respecting and reading are one act — careful attention, item by item. Outside Slavic the root surfaces in Sanskrit *cétati*, “he perceives.”

And then the trail stops. There is **no secure English descendant**, and the two words that look promising are not it: **cheat** is a clipped *escheat*, from Latin *cadere*, “to fall,” and **chit**, the little note, came into English from India. This book would rather hand you nothing than a cousin that is only a resemblance — the care it took with **говорить**, which is not *govern*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “читать” — *chi-TAT'*, the *ch* of *cheese*
- “Я читаю и понимаю” — and hear it as both *read* and *am reading*
- the pair — “читать ... прочитать”, the doing and the read-through

Before you move on

Say “I read and I understand.” (Я читаю и понимаю.) Give the two English sentences я читаю covers, and say why. (*I read* and *I am reading*; **быть** has no present tense to build the second.) Name the finished partner. (Прочитать.) Which two Russian nouns share this root, and is **читать** related to English *cheat*? (Число and честь; and **но** — as **говорить** was not related to *govern*.)

4.4 писать — “to write”

A new letter, an English family you know on sight, and a stress mistake worth naming before you make it.

You’ll want to know first — писать

писать — *pisát'* — **to write**

Stress on the **last** syllable, **pi-SAT'** — not a detail you may skip.

Я пишу. — *ya pishú* — **I write**, and **I am writing**.

Two things moved: the **с** becomes **ш** in the present, and the stress that sat on the ending for *I* jumps back to the stem elsewhere — пишу (*pishú*), but ты пишешь (*píshesh*). The pair runs as **читать**’s did: **писать** ongoing, **написать** finished.

Careful. **Писать** stressed at the end — *pisát'* — is **to write**. **Писать** stressed at the front — *pisat'* — is a child’s word for **to urinate**, whose *I* form is *písayu* beside *pishú*. The two differ only in where your voice lifts, and beginners land on the wrong one. Stress the **end** and say *pishú*.

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Cyrillic.*) All of **писать** is familiar; the new letter arrives in **пишу**.

- **ш** = “**sh**”, the sound of *shoe*. Three uprights on a bar, like a comb with the teeth up.

You have been reading it without being told: **живёшь, знаешь, говоришь** and the past **шёл** all carry it. And note the kind of letter it is: **я** lies to a Latin reader, looking like a mirrored *R* while being a vowel; **ш** resembles nothing Latin at all.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

писать is Indo-European **peyk-*, “**to cut, to scratch, to mark**” — before ink there was a point and a surface. The root became, in Latin, *pingere*, “to paint”, and English took the results: **paint, picture, pigment**. Russian’s **письмо** (a letter) and **писатель** (a writer) sit on the verb.

That closes the chapter’s thread: **думать** came in from Gothic, **понимать** is a root meaning *take*, **читать** a root meaning *count* with no English descendant, and **писать** a root meaning *scratch* that handed English a wall of paint.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**писать**” then “**я пишу**” — stress on the end, and the **ш** arriving
- the four — “**я думаю, я понимаю, я читаю, я пишу**”

Before you move on

Say “I write.” (**Я пишу**.) Where does the stress go, and what if it goes on the front? (On the **end**; *písat’* is a child’s word for urinating.) What sound is **ш**? (**Sh** — **живёшь, знаешь, говоришь, шёл**.) Say the chapter’s four verbs in the *I* form, then their finished partners. (**Я думаю, я понимаю, я читаю, я пишу; подумать, понять, прочитав, написать**.) And what did **писать**’s root mean? (**To scratch** — hence *paint*.)

Chapter 5

Taking, Asking, Helping, Loving

By the end of this chapter: I can say I take, ask, help and love in Russian, put any verb I own after **люблю** as a bare infinitive, and tell a suppletive aspect pair like **брать · взять** from an ordinary one like **спрашивать · спросить**.

*Say я люблю with its inserted л, then run every verb you own through it — я люблю читать, писать, помогать, жить — and close by naming the chapter’s four partners and picking out **взять** as the one built from a different root.*

5.1 брать — “to take”

A short verb, an English cousin you carry every day, and a partner that shares not one letter with it.

You’ll want to know first — брать

брать — *brat’* — to take

Five letters, all of them yours, and the familiar **-ть**.

Я беру. — *ya berú* — I take.

The stem grows a vowel: **бр-** in the infinitive, **бер-** once an ending arrives. Then **ты берёшь**, so this verb sits in the **знать** family, and that **-у** is the plain form of the **-ю** you have been saying.

Three sentences, all ordinary Russian:

Я читаю. Я пишу. Я беру.

Grammar Lens: a pair with nothing in common

The partners so far were recognisable: **читать · прочитать** added a prefix, **понимать · понять** reshaped a middle. Now the hard case.

Брать's finished partner is **взять** — *vzyat'*, **я возьму**, *ya vaz'mú*. Not a prefixed **брать**, not a squeezed one: a **different word entirely**, drafted in as half of the pair.

Grammarians call this **suppletion**, and you have met it once: **идти** takes **шёл** for its past, from another root, exactly as English *go* takes **went**. Here the same trick builds an aspect pair instead of a past tense. There is a quiet reward in it. **Взять** is **вз-** on the very root that built **понимать**, the ancient root meaning *take*. So **брать**'s finished partner is family with the verb for *understand*, and **брать** is the outsider.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

брать is Indo-European **b^her-*, “**to carry, to bear**”, one of the richest roots English owns: **bear, birth, burden, bier**; Latin *ferre* behind **transfer, refer, fertile**; Greek *phérein* behind **metaphor**, a carrying-across. Russian keeps the load too — **бремя** is a burden, and **беременная**, *pregnant*, is literally *carrying*.

Now the trap, because this track flags both kinds. **Брат** means **brother**, sits one soft sign from **брать**, and is **not related**: **брат** is **b^hréh₂ter*, English *brother*. And **быть** is **b^huH-*, English *be*. Three roots that all begin **b^h** — a family accent, not a shared word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**брать**” then “**я беру**” — hear the stem grow its vowel
- “**Я читаю. Я пишу. Я беру.**”
- the odd pair — “**брать ... взять**”, two words sharing nothing
- the other suppletion — “**идти ... шёл**”, “**go ... went**”
- “**брать**” then English “**bear, birth, burden, transfer, metaphor**”

Before you move on

Say “I take.” (Я беру.) Name брать’s finished partner and say what is strange about it, then give the English pair that behaves the same way. (Взять, a different root; *go* and **went**, as идти takes шёл.) Which verb of yours is **взять** related to? (Понимать — both on the old root for *take*.) And is **брать** related to **брат**? (No — different roots, and **быть** is a third.)

5.2 спрашивать — “to ask”

You have asked a question in Russian since Chapter 2 without owning the verb for asking. Here it is.

You’ll want to know first — спрашивать

спрашивать — *spráshivat’* — to ask (a question)

Long on the page, easy in the mouth: the stress lands on **спра-** and stays, **SPRA-shi-vat’**. The **ш** in the middle is the letter пишу introduced.

Я спрашиваю. — *ya spráshivayu* — I ask.

The same -ю, and ты спрашиваешь puts it in the **знать** family. Set it beside your other verb for opening your mouth: **говорить** is to speak, **спрашивать** is to speak with a question mark on the end. And one distinction English hides: Russian asks a **question** with **спрашивать**, but **for a thing** with **просить**.

Grammar Lens: an ordinary pair, after a very strange one

Брать took **взять**, a partner from a different root. That was the worst case, not the norm. **Спрашивать**’s partner is **спросить** — *ya sproshú, ty sprosish* — one root worn into two shapes, the ongoing member long, the finished short.

Why it’s said this way

The moment you ask, Russian makes you choose. **Как вас зовут?** takes **вас** for a stranger and **тебя** for a friend — a choice that sits inside **ты** and **вы**, the split English lost when **thou**, **ты**’s cousin, left ordinary use.

Other languages make the same move by other grammar: French **vous** and Russian **вы** are the plural doing polite duty, German **Sie** borrows the third person, Spanish **usted** grew out of a title.

And recall what that question literally asks: **how** they call you, not what your name is — an action where English reaches for a possession, as French and Spanish also do.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Strip the prefix and **спрашивать** rests on the root of **просить**, “to request”: Indo-European **prek-*, “**to ask**.” In Latin it became *precārī*, “to pray”, and English took the lot: **pray**, **prayer**, **precarious**, **deprecate**. German **fragen** is the Germanic outcome, so **спрашивать** and *fragen* are one inherited word.

English **ask** is not in this family; the cousin kept here is *pray*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “спрашивать” then “я спрашиваю” — and hear the **ш** of **пишу**
- the two mouths — “я говорю ... я спрашиваю”
- “Как вас зовут” then “Как тебя зовут” — and choose which fits

Before you move on

Say “I ask.” (**Я спрашиваю.**) Name the partner and say how this pair differs from **брать · взять**. (**Спросить** — one root in two shapes.) In **Как вас зовут?**, what decides between **вас** and **тебя**? (Whether the person is **вы** or **ты** — and **ты** is English *thou*.) And give an English cousin of **prek-*. (*Pray, prayer, precarious.*)

5.3 помогать — “to help”

This verb is built out of the word for *being able*, and that word is English **may**. Helping, in Russian, is lending someone your can.

You'll want to know first — помогать

помогать — *potogát'* — to help

The *г* is the letter **говорить** introduced: Greek gamma, a hard **g** as in *go*. Both **os** lean towards *a* away from the stress, as **говорить**'s do — **ра-ма-GAT'**.

Я помогаю. — *ya potagáyu* — I help.

Same -ю, and ты помогаешь files it with **знать**.

One honest limit: the person you help takes a case this book has not reached, so keep the sentence bare. Я помогаю alone is ordinary Russian.

Grammar Lens: a partner that does not end in -ть

Every infinitive so far ended in -ть. The partner of **помогать** does not: it is **помочь**, ending in -чь, and *ya potagú, ty potózhesh*.

A small handful of Russian verbs end that way, and they are built on old roots about power. The shape is a signpost, not an exception to memorise blind.

Three pairs cover the chapter so far: **брать · взять, спрашивать · спросить, помогать · помочь**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

помогать is **по-** plus **-мочь**, and under it sits **мочь**, “to be able” — **я могу**, *ya magú*, “I can.”

That root is Indo-European **magh-*, “to be able, to have power”, and English holds several pieces of it:

- **may** and **might** — the ordinary modal, and the noun for strength in *with might and main*.
- **dismay** — to strip someone of their power to act.
- German **mögen** and **Macht**; and Greek *mēkhanē*, “a contrivance”, which is English **machine** and **mechanic**.

Note what did **not** happen here. **Морь** and *may* still mean the same thing after five thousand years. That is not the usual outcome: **жить**'s root handed English **quick**, which once meant **alive** and now means *fast*. Some roots keep their sense, some drift out of recognition, and

спрашивать's went from *ask* all the way to *pray*. Each one has to be checked rather than guessed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “помогать” — *pa-ma-GAT'*, both *os* leaning to *a*
- “Я помогаю”
- the three pairs — “брать · взять, спрашивать · спросить, помогать · помочь”
- “могу” then English “may, might” — one meaning, two languages

Before you move on

Say “I help.” (Я помогаю.) Which verb is hiding inside it, and what does it mean? (Мочь — to be able; я могу.) Name the partner and say what is odd about its ending. (Помочь, in -чь rather than -ть.) Give two English cousins of **mag^h*-. (*May, might, dismay, machine.*) And which English word from your verbs no longer means what its root meant? (**Quick**, from **жить**'s root — it meant *alive*.)

5.4 любить — “to love, and to like”

The last verb of the chapter is English **love**, and it lets you say every verb you own in a real sentence.

You'll want to know first — любить

любить — *lyubít'* — to love, and to like

One verb for both: with a person, *love*; with an activity, closer to *like*.

Я люблю. — *ya lyublyú* — I love.

And ты любишь — an -ишь, so любить joins говорить and видеть, not знать. The stress moves too: *lyublyú* on the ending, *lyúbish* on the stem.

Grammar Lens: the letter that appears out of nowhere

Любить has no л after the б. Люблю does.

You have met this shape. Видеть swapped д for ж in вижу and nowhere else. Here it happens by insertion: stems ending in б, п, в, м, ф push an л in — but **only in the I form**.

So люблю, then любишь, любят, with no л at all. Learn the I form and the rest behaves.

Grammar Lens: now say everything at once

Любить takes a bare infinitive, as English *like* does — the dictionary form goes straight in:

Я люблю читать. — I like reading. Я люблю писать.
— I like writing. Я люблю думать. — I like thinking. Я
люблю помогать. — I like helping. Я люблю жить. —
I love living.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

любить is Indo-European **leubh-*, and English **love** is the same word — no borrowing, no detour. The family is wider than it looks: **lief**; **believe** (*be-* plus the root — to hold a thing dear enough to trust); **leave** in *by your leave*; and Latin *libet*, “it pleases”, behind **libido**.

Its partner полюбить deserves an honest line: not *to finish loving* but **to come to love**, the moment the feeling starts. A pair does not always mean *doing* against *done* — which is why they get a later chapter of their own.

And the root thread: бр- carries (*bear*), -прос- asks (*pray*), мог- is able (*might*), люб- holds dear (*love*) — with пис- from last chapter still scratching its mark (*picture*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “любить” then “я люблю”, then “ты любишь” without the л
- “Я люблю читать. Я люблю писать. Я люблю помогать. Я люблю жить.”

- the four pairs — “брать · взять, спрашивать · спросить, помогать · помочь, любить · полюбить”

Before you move on

Say “I love”, then “I like reading.” (Я люблю; Я люблю читать.) Where is the л in ты любишь, and which earlier verb behaved this way? (Gone — the insert hits only the *I* form, as д → ж in вижу.) Name the chapter’s four partners, and which is a different root from its verb. (Взять, спросить, помочь, полюбить; взять.) And give the English cousins of любить, брать, спрашивать, помогать and писать. (Love, bear, pray, might, picture.)

A note on sources

Etymologies are traced against standard comparative sources for Slavic and Indo-European, and every English cousin claimed here is one the evidence actually supports. Where a resemblance is only a resemblance, the text says so rather than quietly banking it.